

Built by the room

The Assembly is the one day of the year the whole society is in a single place. That makes it the only occasion on which SLS can properly do what it cannot do anywhere else: name the partners, Council members, Chapter teams and contributors who carried the year, in front of everyone whose year they carried. Everything else the day does follows from that.

PROPOSED DATE	VENUE	SHAPE	ROOM	NOT THIS YEAR
Saturday 21 November 2026	Hena Experience Center, Riyadh	One day, 14:30– 21:00	~400 members, all invited	No graduation segment

Recognise. Show. Launch.

To close the SLS year by recognising the people who carried it — partners, Council members, Chapter teams and key contributors — in front of the full membership; to show what their work produced; and to open 2027 with members committed to it before they leave the room.

Three verbs, in that order. Recognition comes first because it is the only thing on the agenda that cannot be done at any other SLS event, and because a society that shows its impact without naming who delivered it has told only half the story.

- Every contributor group named publicly, each with **one specific line** on what they did and what it produced — never a category thanked in the abstract.
- **≥85%** of confirmed guests actually attend. In 2024, 320 of 468 registrants came — 68%.
- Overall satisfaction **≥85%** (2024: 76.8%) and agenda flow **≥85%** (2024: 69.8%, the lowest-scoring item on the survey).
- **≥60** members leave with a named 2027 commitment — a visit hosted, a circle chaired, a chapter opened, a member mentored.
- **≥3** introductions logged per member on the network graph.

Built by the room

Everything on the screen tonight traces back to someone sitting in this room. Next year's will too.

The line does three jobs at once. It makes the recognition argument without a speech — every milestone shown has a person attached, and they are present. It reads backwards as a statement about the year that closed and forwards as an instruction for the one opening. And it survives compression: it works as a stage graphic, an invitation subject line, and four words on a badge.

It also sets an editorial test for the agenda, which is where themes usually stop being useful and this one keeps earning: if a segment does not connect to somebody in the room, it does not belong on the programme.

Everything here has a name on it — more literal, excellent as the headline over the recognition wall, weaker as a stage line and too long for an invitation.

The year, in names — quieter and more formal. Better if the Council wants the tone closer to an honours evening than a community night.

One dependency to book in week one: the Arabic line. It has to carry the meaning rather than translate the words, and the theme drives the invitation, the wall and the stage design — so it cannot be a late decision. Brief comms before anything else is commissioned.

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Format

One day, one room, five movements

DATE	Saturday 21 November 2026, 14:30–21:00 — a single day, ending with dinner
VENUE	Hena Experience Center, Riyadh (proposed, pending site survey)
SCALE	All SLS members invited; around 400 expected
ACCESS	Private, invitation only, guest-list filtration
BALANCE	Roughly two hours seated out of six and a half; the seated block runs once, unbroken, at the end
REGISTER	Formal enough to honour people properly, informal enough that they talk to each other afterwards
LANGUAGE	Bilingual throughout; simultaneous translation in scope

The rule that protects the agenda: **if a segment would work at a Chapter event, it does not belong on the Assembly.**

The Assembly’s only structural advantage over everything else SLS runs is that everyone is there at once. So it should spend itself on the four things that need full scale to mean anything: recognition in front of the whole society, the complete network in one view, cross-chapter and cross-sector mixing that a chapter meeting structurally cannot produce, and decisions that are only legitimate when the whole membership is present.

The arc of the day

Recognition is threaded through the programme rather than parked in an awards block, so nobody is asked to sit through sixty names in a row. Segments marked **RECOGNITION** carry a named moment.

FIVE MOVEMENTS • 390 MINUTES • ~125 SEATED

TIME	MOVEMENT	
14:30 • 60'	I. Arrive into the year The venue is the exhibition, not a holding pen. Badge scan lights your node on the network wall; the Wall of the Year names every contributor; the year's milestones laid out as something you walk through.	RECOGNITION
15:30 • 10'	II. Opening The Council chair against the network wall — the society tonight, who is here, and how it grew.	
15:40 • 25'	The year, told by three members Impact and milestones through three people it happened to, not a slide review. Partners are recognised at the top of this segment, because the impact is what they enabled.	RECOGNITION
16:05 • 10'	Chapters Chapter teams on stage as teams, not as a queue of individuals.	RECOGNITION
16:15 • 50'	III. Peer advisory circles Eight to ten a table, one member's live challenge, Chatham House. Tables mixed by sector from the network graph.	
17:05 • 70'	Impact Market Member-led stands, each carrying one ask. Commitments logged as they are made. Maghrib sits inside this block, not against it.	
18:15 • 30'	IV. Keynote dialogue Two chairs, a member moderating, questions collected from members beforehand.	
18:45 • 15'	Isha	

19:00 · 25´

The Council

Outgoing Council members recognised at the handover, then three decisions put to the room and voted live: which chapter opens next, which visit the society funds, one change to member engagement.

RECOGNITION

19:25 · 15´

The honour, and the welcome

The peer-nominated recognition of the year, followed by new members inducted into the society — named, paired with a sponsor member, the room stands once.

RECOGNITION

19:40 · 10´

V. The replay and the board

Ninety seconds of the network graph replaying from doors to close, lights down. Then the 2027 board opens.

19:50 · 70´

Dinner

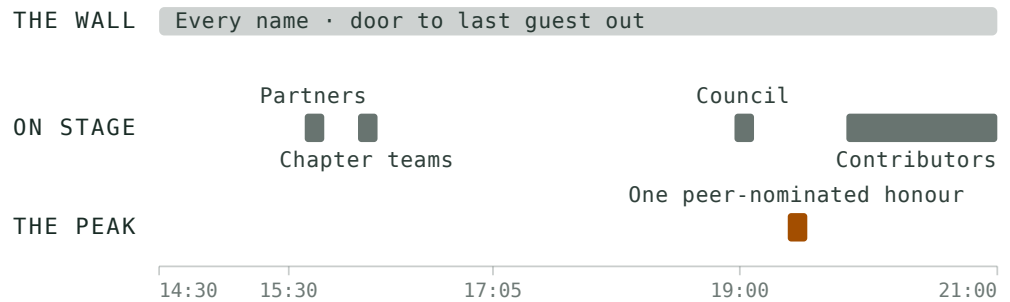
Contributor names on screen throughout. Seating drawn from the graph. 2027 commitments made and photographed on the way out.

RECOGNITION

Compared with a standard convening this trades a second keynote for the recognition moments — the right trade for a year-closing assembly, and one worth stating out loud so it is not quietly reversed during planning.

Three volumes, because sixty names is not a ceremony

Four groups deserve recognition — partners, Council, Chapter teams, contributors — and together they are likely sixty-plus names. Sixty walks to a stage is forty minutes of applause fatigue, and it lands precisely on the thing the 2024 survey scored lowest. Recognition has to be designed at three different volumes.



Recognition fires at three volumes across the day: everyone on the Wall, four groups in context on stage, and one honour at the peak. No group is thanked twice in the same register, and no seated block carries more than ninety seconds of names.

The Wall of the Year

TIER 1 · EVERYONE · ON ARRIVAL

A physical installation at the entrance carrying every partner, Council member, Chapter team and contributor, grouped by *what they did* rather than by rank. Sixty names honoured in the time it takes to walk in — and, done properly, the most photographed object of the night. Guests find their own name before anyone says a word from a stage.

In context, on stage

TIER 2 · FOUR GROUPS · NINETY SECONDS EACH

Each group is recognised inside the segment it belongs to, not queued in an awards block: partners as the impact segment opens, because the impact is what they enabled; Chapter teams during the Chapters segment, called up as teams; the Council at the roadmap handover, which is their work; contributors named on screen through dinner. Every named recognition carries **one specific line** — what they did and what it produced. “Thank you for your support” is worth nothing to an executive.

The peer-nominated honour

TIER 3 · ONE · 19:25

One honour, nominated by members four weeks out through the same flow that confirms their attendance. In a peer society a committee’s choice carries less weight than the room’s, and the nominations are useful twice: they decide the honour, and they hand the Track the specific evidence every Tier 2 line needs.

The letter home. A letter from SLS leadership to the board or CEO of each honoured contributor's organisation. Recognition that reaches an executive's employer outlives anything they can put on a shelf. It costs a signature and it is still remembered a year later.

The workstream this creates: evidence. Every named recognition needs one verified sentence, and those sentences do not exist yet. Chapters and the Council should be asked for them during the planning phase — not in the final week, which is how recognition segments end up generic.

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What makes it
different

Six things a regular SLS event cannot do

The venue is the exhibition on arrival. The first hour is not queueing and coffee. The Wall, the live network graph and the year's milestones are all walkable before anything starts, so arriving early is rewarded rather than endured.

The year is told by three members, not reviewed from a deck. Impact lands when it comes from the person it happened to. It also puts three more names in front of the room without adding a recognition segment.

Chapter teams go up as teams. Six people on stage together for ninety seconds beats six separate walks, and it is a truer picture of how chapter work actually gets done.

Ninety seconds with the lights down. The network graph replays from doors to close, showing every connection made during the day. One image, chosen deliberately, that people photograph.

The 2027 board. Before dinner, members commit publicly to one thing for next year — host a visit, chair a circle, open a chapter, mentor a member. Photographed on the night; it becomes the Council's pipeline in January rather than a follow-up email nobody answers.

The takeaway is personal, not a gift bag. A card carrying your own node, your new connections and your commitment — which keeps the society in front of members through the eleven months when there is no Assembly.

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What this note is waiting on

Decisions needed

- ☐ Confirm 21 November and the 14:30–21:00 window against the Council diary and venue availability.
- ☐ Does SLS already have named recognition categories or awards? This note assumes not and proposes the structure from scratch — if categories exist, they replace Tier 2 wholesale.
- ☐ Approve the theme, and brief comms on the Arabic line in week one.
- ☐ Confirm the Council will put three decisions to a live vote. The segment does not work as a presentation.
- ☐ Agree who signs the letter home, and to whom it goes.
- ☐ Open the peer nomination window four weeks out — needs the member list and the profile flow ready.
- ☐ Confirm whether the new-member induction runs at all this year, given there is no graduation.
- ☐ Budget lines, cost-centre codes and named owners — still TBC on the event charter.

Companion to the **SLS Annual Assembly 2026 event charter**, which carries the approved scope of work, project timeline, stakeholder map, budget lines and risk register, and to the [experience design](#), which holds the full run of show.

Benchmarks are taken from the 2024 post-event report: 468 registrants, 320 attendees, 76.8% overall satisfaction, 27 April 2024 at Misk Schools. Prayer times for 21 November 2026 are approximate and should be confirmed before the run of show is locked.